MOREH NEVUCHIM

Gold Beneath the Surface: Hidden Layers of Torah

Given Tuesday 28 April 2026 · Rambam's Introduction to Moreh Nevuchim: Part 2

Sefer: Moreh Nebuchim (The Guide for the Perplexed) — Rambam **Section:** The Rambam's Introduction (continued) **Text:** Sefaria edition (Rabbi Chaim Makbili's modern Hebrew translation from the Arabic)

Recap: What We've Covered So Far

Shiur 1 (Pre-Pesach): General Introduction

- Rambam's biography and the context in which the Moreh was written
- Overview of the work — three parts, spanning years of study

Shiur 2: The Rambam's Introduction Part 1

- **Why Rambam wrote the book:** Originally individual essays sent to his student Rabbi Yosef, who had to leave. Rambam felt bereft and wanted to pass on these ideas in writing.
- **The purpose of the book:** To explain terms in Tanakh that are multi-meaning, metaphorical, ambiguous, or veiled — giving the educated reader tools to understand what the nevi'im intended.
- **Who the book is for:** A person educated in Torah AND philosophy, of good character, who is perplexed by the tension between philosophical truths and the plain meaning of Torah verses.
- **The two extremes to avoid:** (1) Neglecting your intellect and philosophical understanding, which makes you constantly upset. (2) Neglecting the Torah and foundations of faith. The Moreh tries to balance and reconcile the two.
- **The caveat:** Rambam cannot explain everything exhaustively — these topics touch on Ma'aseh Bereishit (natural science / physics) and Ma'aseh Merkavah (theology / metaphysics), which the Chachamim say you only teach in headlines (rashei perakim).
- **The lightning analogy:** Prophetic experiences are like flashes of lightning in a dark night. Moshe had constant illumination. Most prophets had flashes — sometimes more, sometimes less. The best we can hope for in our generation (without prophecy) is a faint shine, like the glint of a blade. The more you develop character and intellect, the more shine you receive.

This Evening's Shiur

Rambam continues his introduction, explaining three major ideas:

1. **Why deep truths cannot be conveyed directly** — even by those who have attained them
2. **Why the Torah begins with Bereishit** — a fascinating alternative to Rashi's famous answer
3. **The nature and importance of meshalim (parables/analogies)** — with several beautiful Midrashim

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Part 1: Why Deep Truths Cannot Be Fully Expressed

Even the one who attains truth struggles to convey it

דע שמי שירצה אחד מן השלמים לפי דרגת שלמותו להביע דבר מה שבין מאותם הסודות... לא יוכל להבהיר בשלמות כסדר אפילו את המידה שהשיג

- A person who has attained deep understanding — whether through prophecy, illumination, or intellect — **cannot fully express what they've understood**, whether verbally or in writing.
- This is not a failure of effort. It is the nature of these truths.

The flickering quality of understanding

- Even when teaching others, a person will find that **sometimes they can explain more fully, sometimes less, and sometimes not at all.**
- Understanding is like tuning a radio — even prophets had to "tune in." Sometimes they needed external aids (music, meditation) to access prophetic states.
- **Chaim Vital** wrote in his Sefer HaChezyonot that for two years (ages 23–25) he could not study Torah at all. Illumination comes and goes — across years, months, days, even hours.
- Therefore, what you understood on day one you may not be able to express on day two.

The necessity of meshalim

לכן כאשר כיוון כל חכם אלוהי רבני... לא דיבר בהם בשמם המפורשות

- Because these truths resist direct expression, **any rav or chacham who attains deep truth is almost forced to convey it through analogy and metaphor.**
- Think of a sunset, a mountaintop experience, the feeling of being in love — how can you put these into words? You can only approximate through comparison and imagery.
- **This is why the nevi'im, the Torah, and the Chachamim all use meshalim.** It's not a literary choice — it's a necessity imposed by the nature of the subject matter.

Part 2: Why the Torah Begins with Bereishit

The Rambam's answer vs. Rashi's answer

Rashi's famous question and answer (from Rabbi Yitzchak):

- Why does the Torah begin with Bereishit instead of the first mitzvah?
- Answer: So the nations cannot accuse Israel of stealing the land — כוח מעשיו הגיד לעמו לתת להם נחלת גויים. God created the world and gave each part to whom He chose.

Rambam gives a completely different answer:

הלא תראה שכאשר רצה השם יתברך להשלימנו ולתקן מצבי חברתנו במצוות המעשיות...

The logic runs as follows:

1. **Hashem gave us the Torah and mitzvot for our good** — to make us the best people we can be.
2. **But mitzvot cannot be performed properly without understanding who we are doing them for.** You can't just perform mitzvot like a robot — shake the lulav, sit in the sukkah, blow the shofar — without understanding why, what, and who for.
3. **Understanding God requires the study of theology/metaphysics** (חכמת האלוהות).

4. **But metaphysics can only be understood after the study of physics/natural science** (חכמת הטבע) — physics borders on and precedes metaphysics in the order of learning.
5. **Therefore the Torah begins with Bereishit — which is natural science** — because that is the first rung on the ladder.

The progression: Physics → Metaphysics → Understanding God → Performing mitzvot with full recognition of Hakadosh Baruch Hu.

Bereishit contains deep secrets

ומשום גודל העניין ונכבדותו... סתם לך הכתוב בראשית ברא אלוהים

- Bereishit is the study of science — Rambam says this unambiguously.
- But it contains within it deep secrets that Hakadosh Baruch Hu couched in very simple terms.
- A child of four or five reads בראשית ברא אלוהים את השמים ואת הארץ — in the beginning God created heaven and earth — and understands the simple meaning.
- **But clearly there is something far deeper.** The simple reading is for children and simple people. There are multiple layers.
- The Chachamim in the Midrash say: **להגיד כוח מעשה בראשית לבשר ודם אי אפשר** — it's not possible to tell flesh and blood the full power of creation.

Shlomo's observation

אמרתי אחכמה והיא רחוקה ממני

- Creation happened a very long time ago — **רחוק מה שהיה** — and is profoundly deep — **ועמוק עמוק מי ימצאנו**

Multi-layered language is deliberate

בכל זה נעשה שימוש במונחים רב משמעיים כדי שההמון יבינו אותם כפי כוח הבנתם

- The Torah deliberately uses terms and phrases that are **multi-layered** — so the masses understand them simply, and the more developed person plumbs the deeper meaning.
- This is what the Chachamim mean by **שבעים פנים לתורה** — the Torah deliberately allows multiple interpretations so each person can access it at their level.
- **Yom Echad, Yom Sheni, Yom Shlishi** — for the simple person, day one, day two, day three. But clearly there is something far deeper.

Part 3: Rambam's Abandoned Projects

The book on prophecy and the book of correlation

- In his Peirush HaMishnayot (Sanhedrin), as a young man, Rambam announced he would later write:

1. A book explaining the concepts of prophecy
2. A "book of correlation" (ספר ההתאמה) — explaining all the difficult drashot of Chazal whose surface meaning seems far from truth

Why he abandoned them

לא היה טוב בעינינו מה שהתחלנו לבאר בדרך הזאת

He was stuck either way (מנא נפשך):

- **Option A:** Fully expose the deeper meaning of the drashot → but this violates the principle that these truths are deliberately cloaked. The Chachamim and nevi'im intentionally used meshalim to veil them.
- **Option B:** Explain the mashal by giving another mashal → but what's the point of replacing the Chachamim's mashal with his own?

Either way he couldn't win — so he abandoned the project. He settled for explaining the basics of faith in the Mishneh Torah instead.

Part 4: Three Types of People and How They Read Drashot

Type 1: The Ignoramus (בור)

- Reads statements of the Chachamim that seem to defy reality — e.g., the stories in Bava Batra about Rabbah bar bar Chanah seeing a fish the size of an island, geese dripping with oil, etc.
- **Accepts everything literally** because they don't understand natural science — the impossible seems possible to them.
- This includes people who know all the halachot and are called great rabbanim, but will accept the most impossible things as literally true because they don't want to think the Chachamim were wrong.
- Rambam's position: the impossible does not happen. You cannot accept ridiculous ideas at face value.

Type 2: The intellectual who rejects

- Reads the same statements and says: **"This is ridiculous. The person who said this is foolish."**
- This is bad — but Rambam makes a remarkable statement: **ואין בכך הרס יסודות האמונה** — this does NOT destroy the foundations of faith.
- Why? Because at least this person isn't ascribing impossible things to the Chachamim. He may be wrong to think badly of them, but he's not corrupting his understanding of reality.

Type 3: The ideal — recognizing deeper meaning

או שיניח שיש להן תוך

- Reads the statements and recognizes: **there must be a deeper meaning here.**
- Whether or not he understands what the deeper meaning is, he at least knows the surface reading is not the full picture.
- **This is the correct approach** — and the one Rambam writes the Moreh for.

Part 5: The Importance of Meshalim — Three Beautiful Midrashim

Midrash 1: The Well and the Rope

למה היו דברי תורה דומים עד שלא עמד שלמה? לבאר שהיו מימיה עמוקים וצוננים ולא היה אדם יכול לשתות מהם

- Until Shlomo, the words of Torah were like a well of deep, cold water — nobody could drink from it.
- **What did a clever person do?** He connected one strand to another, made a rope, and drew out the water.

Shlomo wove mashal to mashal, word to word, until the Torah could be — **כך היה שלמה ממשל למשל** accessed.

- That's why the book is called **Mishlei** — it's the collection of ropes for drawing water from the Torah's depths.
- **What was too deep to access?** Not the laws of Sukkah or Choshen Mishpat — the deeper things, matters of metaphysics and theology.

Midrash 2: The Candle and the Diamond

זה שאבד סלע או מרגלית בתוך ביתו. עד שהוא מדליק פתילה באיסר מוצאת המרגלית

- A person lost a precious diamond somewhere in his dark house.
- He lights a cheap candle — worth a few pennies — and finds the diamond worth thousands.

כך המשל הזה אינו כלום — the mashal itself looks like nothing, looks cheap, looks superficial. But with it, you find the diamonds of Torah.

- **The Rambam draws out the layers:**
- The diamond = the deep truths of Torah (**דברי תורה הם מרגלית**)
- The dark house = our state of not understanding
- The cheap candle = the mashal — seemingly worthless, but the key to finding everything
- The diamond is there in the house, you own it — but without the candle, it's as if you've lost it entirely

The Pasuk: Golden Apples in Silver Settings

תפוחי זהב במשכיות כסף דבר דבור על אופניו

Shlomo HaMelech in Mishlei — golden apples in silver settings is a word spoken properly.

Rambam's reading:

- **Maskiyot** = settings with tiny holes (eyelets) — like silverwork with minute openings
- From a distance, you see silver and think it's a silver apple
- **But if you look closely through the tiny holes — you see gold inside**

The application:

- The **outer meaning** (the simple reading) should be good — like silver. It has value.
- The **inner meaning** should be better — like gold exceeding silver.
- The outer meaning should contain enough hints — like the eyelets — to show the perceptive reader that there is something deeper within.
- **The nevi'im's meshalim work exactly this way:** the surface is useful (ethical wisdom, social guidance), but the depths contain **אמונות אמת אמיתית** — genuine truths of faith.

Part 6: Two Types of Meshalim in Tanakh

Rambam introduces a crucial distinction for studying his book and all of Tanakh:

Type 1: Every word matters

- Some meshalim in Tanakh are constructed so that **every single word in the mashal has a deeper meaning.**
- Next week's example: **Yaakov's ladder** — every element (the ladder, the angels, ascending, descending, Hashem standing above) carries specific meaning.

Type 2: The general concept matters

- Other meshalim are very long and verbose, but **not every word adds meaning to the deeper idea.**
- Extra words serve to:
- Make the mashal more attractive and complete as a story
- **Deliberately deepen the concealment** — paradoxically, more words can hide the meaning more effectively
- Next week's example: **The seductive woman in Mishlei** — a long mashal about adultery, but the point is the general concept, not every individual word.

This is an important warning for studying the Moreh: Don't over-analyze every word in every mashal. Some meshalim are Type 1 (every word matters), some are Type 2 (general concept matters). Knowing which is which is part of the skill.

Summary of This Evening

1. **Deep truths cannot be conveyed directly** — even those who attain them struggle to express them. The nature of these truths forces the use of meshalim.
2. **The Torah begins with Bereishit because it is natural science** — the first rung on the ladder from physics → metaphysics → understanding God → proper performance of mitzvot. This is a fundamentally different answer from Rashi.
3. **Bereishit is multi-layered** — simple meaning for simple people, deeper meaning for developed minds. שבעים פנים לתורה.
4. **Rambam abandoned his earlier projects** (book on prophecy, book of correlation) because he couldn't resolve the dilemma of either exposing too much or just replacing one mashal with another.
5. **Three types of readers:** the ignoramus who accepts the impossible literally; the intellectual who rejects and thinks badly of the Chachamim (bad, but not a destruction of faith); and the ideal reader who recognizes deeper meaning.
6. **Meshalim are essential, not optional** — three Midrashim illustrate this: the well and the rope, the candle and the diamond, golden apples in silver settings.
7. **Two types of meshalim** — every word matters vs. general concept matters. We will see examples of each next week.

Coming Up Next

- **Two examples of the two types of meshalim:** Yaakov's ladder (every word matters) and the seductive woman in Mishlei (general concept)
- **Rambam's advice on how to study the Moreh**
- **Seven reasons for apparent contradictions in the Moreh** — which concludes the introduction
- Then we begin Part One, Chapter One — the actual discussion of specific terms in Tanakh

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B'Ezrat Hashem

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